

THE
INTIMATE
COVENANT

A TEACHING SERIES
FROM R.C. SPOUL'S
THE INTIMATE MARRIAGE

TEACHING SERIES • PANEL 1 OF 8

MARRIAGE IS A DIVINE COVENANT

God's Design, God's Gift, God's Authority



*“Therefore a man shall leave
his father and his mother and
hold fast to his wife, and the two
shall become one flesh.”*

GENESIS 2:24



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

Marriage is ordained by God, not invented by man.

Marriage is a divine covenant. It is not merely a human arrangement or a private relationship. God Himself designed it, regulates it, and gave it as His answer to human loneliness.



KEY DISTINCTION

More than a feeling. More than a contract.

Marriage is more than romantic love, personal compatibility, or a legal contract. It is a covenant established by God, marked by public vows, made before Him and witnessed by others.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Genesis 2:18 *“It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper fit for him.”*

Genesis 2:24 *“The two shall become one flesh.”*

Matthew 19:4–6 *“What God has joined together, let not man separate.”*

1 Corinthians 7:2 *“Each man should have his own wife, and each woman her own husband.”*



COMMON ERROR

Treating marriage as a human invention.

Many view marriage as a private arrangement, a temporary commitment, or simply a legal contract. Others reduce it to romantic feelings or personal fulfillment. These views ignore God's design, diminish His authority, and leave marriage vulnerable to whatever circumstances or emotions arise.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Receive marriage as a gift from God, and live it under His authority.

Approach your marriage with reverence, recognizing it as God's provision for companionship, intimacy, and covenantal commitment. Make and keep your vows before God. Honor marriage as a lifelong union, seeking His wisdom, strength, and grace to fulfill your responsibilities.



CARRY TRUTH

*Marriage belongs to God
before it belongs to us.*



THE
INTIMATE
COVENANT

A TEACHING SERIES
FROM R.C. SPROUL'S
THE INTIMATE MARRIAGE

TEACHING SERIES • PANEL 2 OF 8

NAKED AND UNASHAMED

The Beauty of Intimacy in God's Design



*"The man and his wife
were both naked and
were not ashamed."*

GENESIS 2:25



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

God designed marriage for intimate vulnerability without shame.

From the beginning, God created marriage as a unique human relationship where a man and a woman can be fully known, fully exposed, and fully loved.



KEY DISTINCTION

Innocent openness vs. shame-filled hiding.

In Eden, intimacy was marked by trust and openness—naked and unashamed. After the fall, sin introduced shame, fear, and hiding. Marriage provides a divinely given context where we can pursue deep vulnerability again.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Genesis 2:25 *"The man and his wife were both naked and were not ashamed."*

Genesis 3:7–10 After sin, they hid from God and from one another.

Ecclesiastes 4:9–12 *Two are better than one ... for if one falls, the other will lift him up."*

Song of Solomon 4:7 *"You are altogether beautiful, my love; there is no flaw in you."*



COMMON ERROR

Seeing intimacy as dangerous or shameful.

Because of sin, many enter marriage carrying shame, fear, or the belief that real intimacy will lead to rejection, humiliation, or control. Some hide their true thoughts, struggles, or weaknesses, or they reduce intimacy to mere physicality. These errors prevent the deep "knowing" that God designed marriage to provide.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Pursue honest, grace-filled vulnerability with your spouse.

Create a safe place where you can share your true self—your fears, failures, questions, and desires—without fear of humiliation. Fight the tendency to hide. Confess sin, seek forgiveness, and receive your spouse with the same grace you have received from God.



CARRY TRUTH

*Intimacy is the freedom to
be known without being humiliated.*

STUDY YOUR SPOUSE

Intimacy Requires a Lifelong Pursuit of Knowledge



*"You cannot be intimate
with someone you do not know.
Marriage therefore becomes
a lifelong study of the person
God has given you."*

R.C. SPROUL



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

Intimacy requires knowledge.

God intends marriage to be a deep and growing intimacy. That intimacy is built through real knowledge of one another. To be truly intimate is to know your spouse — their fears, hopes, feelings, desires, and why they react as they do.



KEY DISTINCTION

Assumptions vs. careful, ongoing study.

Do not assume you already know what matters to your spouse. Sproul emphasizes that many marital failures come from not asking, not listening, and not taking the time to understand the inner life of the one God has given you.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Genesis 2:18 *"The LORD God said, 'It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper fit for him.'"*

Proverbs 18:13 *"He who answers a matter before he hears it, it is folly and shame to him."*

James 1:19 *"Let every person be quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger."*



COMMON ERROR

Thinking you already know your spouse.

Many spouses stop asking questions and assume they understand what is important to the other. They ignore their spouse's feelings, discourage honest communication, or fail to listen carefully. This leads to misunderstanding, distance, and a loss of intimacy.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Ask, listen, and keep learning.

Make the study of your spouse a lifelong pursuit. Ask good questions. Listen patiently. Seek to understand your spouse's fears, hopes, and desires. Pay attention to their "felt needs." Be attentive to how they are thinking and feeling, and why they respond as they do.



CARRY TRUTH

*You cannot be intimate
with someone you have stopped learning.*

SEX: INTIMACY WITHOUT FEAR OR GUILT

A God-Given Gift Within the Covenant



"Let the marriage bed be undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterous."

HEBREWS 13:4



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

Sexual intimacy is a good gift from God within the marriage covenant.

God designed sexual intimacy as a beautiful part of marriage. It deepens the one-flesh union, expresses love, strengthens the emotional bond, and is a source of joy and delight between husband and wife.



KEY DISTINCTION

Covenant intimacy vs. sinful sexuality.

Sex was designed for the covenant of marriage, not for casual relationships or self-gratification outside of God's design. Within marriage, sex is holy, good, and unashamed. Outside of marriage, it distorts God's purpose and brings guilt, confusion, and harm.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Genesis 2:24 *"The two shall become one flesh."*

Song of Solomon 1:2 *"Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for your love is better than wine."*

1 Corinthians 7:3–5 *"Do not deprive one another except by agreement, that you may devote yourselves to prayer."*

Hebrews 13:4 *"Let the marriage bed be undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterous."*



COMMON ERROR

Approaching sex with fear, guilt, or selfishness.

Many bring fear, past sins, or unresolved guilt into marriage, which can paralyze intimacy. Others treat sex as merely a physical release or as something only the husband desires. These errors rob the marriage of the joy, closeness, and one-flesh unity God intends.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Receive and enjoy God's gift with a clear conscience and a loving heart.

Pursue sexual intimacy within marriage without fear or shame. If real guilt from past sin remains, bring it to Christ—His forgiveness is real and sufficient. Communicate openly, learn each other's needs, and view intimacy as a shared gift that strengthens your love, unity, and lifelong covenant.



CARRY TRUTH

*God's answer to real guilt
is real forgiveness.*



YOUR WORDS BUILD THE MARRIAGE YOU LIVE IN

The Environment of Intimacy — The Power of Words



*“Gracious words are a
honeycomb, sweet to the soul
and healing to the bones.”*

PROVERBS 16:24



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

Words are a powerful force in marriage.

The way we speak to and about our spouse creates the environment for intimacy. Words can either build trust, safety, and closeness—or they can wound, create distance, and slowly destroy the marriage God has given.



KEY DISTINCTION

Building words vs. destroying words.

Affirming, encouraging, and appreciative words strengthen a spouse's heart. Critical, sarcastic, or harsh words communicate disapproval, degrade the soul, and create emotional distance that is hard to repair.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Proverbs 16:24 *“Gracious words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul and healing to the bones.”*

Ephesians 4:29 *“Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for building up, as fits the occasion ...”*

Proverbs 25:11 *“A word fitly spoken is like golden apples in a setting of silver.”*



COMMON ERROR

Taking a critical attitude or speaking thoughtlessly.

Many minimize the damage of negative words, thinking “I’m just being honest,” “I was only joking,” or “That’s how I am.” Others focus on what is wrong with their spouse rather than what is good and true. Repeated criticism, complaining, or sarcasm erodes intimacy and communicates that the spouse is not valued.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Speak life to your spouse.

Make a deliberate effort to encourage, affirm, and speak with grace. Look for genuine ways to compliment your spouse—Sproul highlights the need for many affirming words to outweigh one critical word (aim for about a 9:1 ratio). Replace criticism with appreciation. Pray for wisdom to use your words to build up and strengthen your marriage.



CARRY TRUTH

*Your words create the environment
in which intimacy either flourishes or withers.*



ORDERED ROLES WITHOUT A POWER STRUGGLE

Different Roles for One Shared Mission

"The husband is called to love and lead, and the wife is called to respect and support. These different roles are designed by God to work together, not to compete."

R.C. SPROUL



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

God designed distinct roles for a complementary partnership.

Marriage is not a competition for power but a divinely designed partnership. The husband is called to loving, responsible leadership, and the wife is called to supportive, respectful submission. Different roles bring harmony and strength to the marriage covenant.



KEY DISTINCTION

Complementary roles vs. competing roles.

God gives the husband and wife different responsibilities, not to establish a hierarchy of worth, but to create a complementary relationship. Headship is not domination, and submission is not servitude. When each fulfills their God-given role, marriage reflects God's design and brings greater unity.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Genesis 2:18 *"The LORD God said, 'It is not good for the man to be alone; I will make him a helper fit for him.'"*

Ephesians 5:22–25 *"Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord... Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her."*

Colossians 3:18 *"Wives, submit to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord."*



COMMON ERROR

Seeing God's order as oppression or outdated.

Many reject distinct roles because they see headship and submission as unfair, oppressive, or merely a cultural relic. Others turn it into a power struggle, forgetting that God's design is for harmony, not control. When either spouse seeks to erase their role or use their role for selfish gain, the beauty of marriage is lost.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Embrace your role as a gift, not a burden.

Husbands, lead with love, responsibility, and sacrifice, seeking your wife's good. Wives, support, respect, and encourage your husband, trusting God's design. Work together as a team, using your different strengths to fulfill God's purposes in your home and to glorify Him.



CARRY TRUTH

*God's order is designed for harmony,
not a contest for control.*

THE
INTIMATE
COVENANT

A TEACHING SERIES
FROM R.C. SPOUL'S
THE INTIMATE MARRIAGE

TEACHING SERIES • BONUS 1 OF 2

PDCA IN THE GARDEN OF MARRIAGE

A Practical Rhythm for a Growing Covenant

*"A marriage, like a garden,
does not grow by accident.
It must be tended with
intentional care."*

R.C. SPOUL

1

PLAN

Set the Direction Together



- Talk about your hopes, goals, and priorities for your marriage.
- Seek God's wisdom through prayer and Scripture.
- Be intentional about the kind of marriage you want to build.

Key Thought:

A growing marriage begins with intentional planning, not leaving it to chance.

2

DO

Put It into Practice



- Practice the principles of intimacy from this series.
- Love, serve, and communicate in everyday life.
- Take small, consistent steps toward greater closeness.

Key Thought:

A healthy marriage grows through faithful, daily practice – not just good intentions.

3

CHECK

Evaluate and Be Honest



- Regularly assess how your marriage is doing.
- Ask: Are we experiencing greater intimacy, trust, and joy?
- Be open about struggles such as hiding, fear, guilt, or hurtful words.

Key Thought:

Honest evaluation helps you see what is working and what needs attention.

4

ADJUST

Make Changes and Keep Growing



- Make needed changes together.
- Repent quickly when you have hurt one another.
- Seek forgiveness and extend grace.
- Keep learning, keep communicating, and keep pursuing a deeper intimacy.

Key Thought:

A thriving marriage adjusts and keeps growing by the grace of God.



CARRY TRUTH

*Healthy marriages are cultivated,
not assumed.*

THE INTIMATE COVENANT

A TEACHING SERIES
FROM R.C. SPOUL'S
THE INTIMATE MARRIAGE

TEACHING SERIES • BONUS 1B OF 2

PDCA IN OTHER AREAS IN MARRIAGE

Applying the Same Rhythm Beyond Sexual Intimacy



"A healthy marriage requires intentional effort in all areas, not just in the bedroom. Like a garden, it must be tended with a plan."

R.C. SPOUL

1

PLAN

Set the Direction Together



- Identify the area you want to grow in (see list at right).
- Talk together about your goals and what you need.
- Seek God's wisdom through prayer and Scripture.
- Decide on specific, realistic steps to take.

Key Thought:

Intentional planning keeps you from drifting and gives you a shared purpose in each area of marriage.

2

DO

Put It into Practice



- Put your plan into action in everyday life.
- Love, serve, and encourage each other.
- Be consistent, even in small things.
- Practice new habits and patterns together.

Key Thought:

Growth happens when good intentions become daily practice.

3

CHECK

Evaluate and Be Honest



- Regularly assess how it is going in each area.
- Ask: What is working well? What needs attention?
- Be honest about struggles without blame or defensiveness.
- Listen to your spouse's perspective.

Key Thought:

Honest evaluation helps you see progress and spots that need care.

4

ADJUST

Make Changes and Keep Growing



- Make needed changes together.
- Repent quickly when you have hurt one another.
- Seek forgiveness and extend grace.
- Keep learning, keep communicating, and keep pursuing a deeper intimacy in every area.

Key Thought:

A thriving marriage continually adjusts and grows by the grace of God.

KEY AREAS IN MARRIAGE



Communication

Listening, speaking, and understanding



Conflict Resolution

Responding with grace and forgiveness



Finances

Stewardship and decision-making



Family Life

Parenting and home responsibilities



Time Together

Priorities and intentional connection



Spiritual Growth

Praying, reading Scripture, and worshiping together



Extended Family and Relationships

Setting boundaries and loving well



CARRY TRUTH

The same simple rhythm can help you cultivate a healthier marriage in every area of life together.



THE
INTIMATE
COVENANT

A TEACHING SERIES
FROM R.C. SPOUL'S
THE INTIMATE MARRIAGE

TEACHING SERIES • BONUS 2 OF 2

SEXUAL INTIMACY— WOMEN

Understanding a Woman's Design and Desires

"A woman's sexual desire is different from a man's. God has designed her with a different tempo, focus, and pathway to arousal within the marriage covenant."

R.C. SPOUL



KINGDOM PRINCIPLE

God designed women differently in their sexual desire.

A woman's sexual desire is real and good, but it is constructed differently than a man's. God has designed women with a greater need for emotional intimacy, security, and affection as part of the pathway to sexual desire.



KEY DISTINCTION

Women are responsive; men are spontaneous.

Men often experience sexual desire quickly and spontaneously, while most women typically experience desire in response to love, affection, emotional connection, and a sense of security. This is not a deficiency, but a divinely intended difference in design.



KEY SCRIPTURES

Song of Solomon 1:2 *"Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for your love is better than wine."*

Proverbs 5:18–19 *"Let your fountain be blessed, and rejoice in the wife of your youth ... Let her breasts satisfy you at all times, and always be enchanted with her love."*

1 Corinthians 7:3–5 *"The wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband does ..."*



COMMON ERROR

Expecting women to desire sex like men.

Many husbands become frustrated when their wife's desire does not match their own. They may misinterpret a lower or slower desire response as rejection or lack of love. Others pressure or manipulate their wife, which damages intimacy and trust. Failing to understand and respect a woman's design leads to unnecessary conflict and distance.



KINGDOM APPLICATION

Love, serve, and create the conditions for desire.

Husbands, pursue your wife with patient love, emotional intimacy, and thoughtful affection. Invest in your relationship, help with burdens, and create a safe and secure environment. Seek to understand her needs and communicate openly. When a wife feels loved, respected, and secure, her desire for intimacy typically grows. Embrace the differences God has given as a gift for a richer, deeper union.



CARRY TRUTH

*A woman's design is different,
but her desire is real and good.*

